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‘Safeguarding the rights and interests of the Mussalmans’

Mohammad Ali Jinnah and Jawaharlal Nehru discuss Muslim representation and the ‘communal question’



AFTER A SERIES of personal tragedies that culminated in the death of his wife Kamala in February 1936, for whose treatment he had travelled to Germany, France and Switzerland, Jawaharlal Nehru returned to India to take up the presidency of the Indian National Congress for the second time.[1] Six months later, amidst heavy August downpours, Jawaharlal Nehru fought his way through the flooded roads of Lucknow to Ganga Prasad Memorial Hall, where he appeared on stage with Mohammad Ali Jinnah. Both men had followed the invitation of the All-India Student Federation, a relatively recent addition to the growing list of outspokenly anti-colonial student unions.

It was the first and last time they would share a podium. Jinnah, the president of the Muslim League, a party founded to voice the interests of Muslims on the national level in colonial India, was presiding and spoke a few introductory words on the future task of students in the freedom struggle against British rule. He praised Nehru for ‘his sincerity and genuineness of purpose’. While for the moment they were speaking for different political bodies, their love for their ‘motherland was common’. Nehru was less conciliatory and plunged straight into a new set of political